

Long time coming: Carlos Sainz delivered Williams its first podium since 2021. PICS: REUTERS

Norris to chip away at the championship deficit, closing the gap by six points to 25.

Yet Norris, too, left frustrated: a disappointing seventh on the grid left him boxed in, and seventh was all he could salvage on Sunday. With rivals ahead profiting from a turbulent qualifying session derailed by crashes, rain, and chaos, the Briton saw a golden chance slip away.

Instead of emerging as the main beneficiary of McLaren's rivals' misfortune, Norris spent much of the race trapped in traffic, unable to show the raw pace that has defined his season so far. For a driver chasing his first world title, the sense of a squandered opportunity was unmistakable.

Qualifying, as often in Baku, was a story in itself. While practice ran smoothly, the Saturday shootout descended into mayhem. Lasting an extraordinary one hour and 58 minutes — longer than the entire 2024 Grand Prix — the session produced six red flags, a new record that surpassed the five seen at Imola 2022 and Sao Paulo 2024. Three stoppages in Q1, one in Q2, and two in Q3 left drivers scrambling for a single flawless lap.

Charles Leclerc's hunt for a fifth



straight Baku pole ended in the barriers during Q3. By that stage, Sainz had surprisingly topped the timesheets, with the clock ticking down amid treacherous dry-wet conditions. Piastri, too, was caught out, damaging his car heavily.

For a brief spell, it looked as though Sainz might start from pole position, but Verstappen, calm as ever, produced one of the cleanest laps in the dying moments to snatch it away. That confidence and momentum he carried seamlessly into Sunday's lights-to-flag victory, his 67th career win and second in the Azeri city.

Battle intensifies

Having slashed the championship gap to within 70 points with his rejuvenated form, Verstappen thrives in the role of chaser. But McLaren's dominance, should it regroup swiftly, remains a formidable obstacle.

For now, it has two weeks to recalibrate before the United States Grand Prix. It must resolve internal frailties quickly, with a resurgent Red Bull and a relentless Verstappen looming large. With seven races remaining, the battle for the 2025 world championship is not over. In fact, Baku may have just lit the fuse.



MotoGP

The MotoGP season lit up with consecutive classics in Catalonia and San Marino. At the Circuit de Barcelona-Catalunya, Alex Marquez (right) stunned the paddock by beating his brother Marc (left) to claim victory and end Marc's extraordinary 15-race unbeaten run across Grands Prix and sprints. It was Alex's second win of the season, and he did so at the Marquez brothers' home race amid great fanfare. However, the champion wasted little time in reasserting control and struck back in Italy. A week later at Misano, Marc converted pole into a commanding win in the San Marino GP. Marco Bezzecchi, who had triumphed in Saturday's sprint, finished second, while Alex completed the podium in third. The back-to-back duels have ignited the Marquez brothers' rivalry, though Marc is already on the cusp of a seventh title.

